

Chapter 128-1

Traffic flowed like shuttles on the road, and the sound of tires rubbing against the ground seemed particularly jarring at this moment.

The spring breeze carried fine threads of rain over, making the branches that had just sprouted green buds appear even more tender and delicate.

In an instant, this city gained warmth.

The young woman wore a white dress, her long hair slightly curled, with a very standard oval face. She had paired a denim jacket over her white dress, looking gentle yet full of vitality.

The wispy hair on her forehead was dampened by sweat and rain. Under Liang Shi's prolonged silent gaze, she reached up to touch the stray hairs on her forehead.

Her hands still had mud from having just moved flower pots, her palms fair with a rosy tint—one could tell at a glance that she was pampered and had never done much dirty or heavy work.

Being stared at by Liang Shi with such a complicated gaze, she felt a bit embarrassed, awkwardly smiling as she wiped her face.

Unable to endure this silence any longer, she said sheepishly, "Is there something on my face?"

Only then did Liang Shi come back to her senses, also realizing her rudeness just now, and immediately said, "Sorry."

"It's fine, it's fine." The young woman said, pausing for a moment. "You look a bit familiar to me."

Liang Shi was surprised. "Hm?"

"That's right!" The young woman's eyes lit up. "You played Wang Jing, right?"

Wang Jing was a role Liang Shi had played not long after her debut—a workplace newbie.

When that drama aired, everyone was saying: We're all Wang Jing, but none of us are as good as Wang Jing.

That role had also gained her quite a few fans, as well as nationwide recognition.

Liang Shi nodded, but still asked unwillingly, "Besides in the TV drama? You haven't seen me anywhere else?"

After saying this, she introduced herself, "My name is Liang Shi."

"Only on TV." The young woman smiled. "How would ordinary people like us ever cross paths with big celebrities like you?"

But a moment later, the young woman asked in surprise, "But... how did you know my name is Qi Jiao?"

Liang Shi stared at her face.

Even if they had looked sixty to seventy percent similar during puberty, a plastic surgeon couldn't possibly imagine what a person would look like as an adult based on their adolescent appearance.

So Qi Jiao's face wasn't very similar to Gu Xingyue's. Even if Yang Jiani had found a particularly skilled plastic surgeon, it would have been impossible to replicate Gu Xingyue into a second Qi Jiao.

They looked sixty to seventy percent alike during puberty, and now they were still sixty to seventy percent alike.

Not a bit more.

The reason Liang Shi had subconsciously called out Qi Jiao's name was entirely based on photos of Qi Jiao from her adolescence.

The Qi Jiao from back then hadn't changed much from now—she was almost like an enlarged version.

Her brows and eyes had fully grown in, the corners of her lips curved in a smile, gentle and beautiful.

Only she was missing the melancholic air that had been visible in the photos before.

It seemed she was living happily.

Liang Shi thought for a moment, then said in a low voice, "I have a friend who's also named Qi Jiao, and she looks a lot like you."

"Is that so..." Qi Jiao nodded to herself. "That's quite a coincidence."

The spring rain began to patter down again. In front of the flower shop, there was only an eave a few dozen centimeters wide to shelter from the rain, and Liang Shi was completely exposed to it.

Qi Jiao stood under the eave, the wind blowing her white dress.

Liang Shi suddenly thought of Chen Mian's profile picture. She pressed her lips together and asked, "Do you know Chen Mian?"

Qi Jiao shook her head, the movement somewhat slow. She knocked on her own head. "I don't know, but the name does sound familiar to me too."

Qi Jiao said that she had once had a high fever in middle school that lasted three days and three nights, and she nearly became an idiot from the fever. After that, her memory became very poor.

She would often forget trivial things in life, and couldn't really remember some people either.

"Middle school?" Liang Shi sensitively caught onto this timeframe. "When was it?"

"Third year of middle school."¹ Qi Jiao said, "My parents said it was because of too much academic pressure. After the fever, my brain became really sluggish, and I didn't have any talent for studying at all. I didn't get into my desired school, and my high school studies were also mediocre. It was just terrible."

"No." Liang Shi immediately said, "You're not terrible at all."

—You're amazing.

In third year of middle school, Qi Jiao had died in that world.

In third year of middle school, Qi Jiao suddenly developed a high fever here.

Was there some connection between these events?

"How can you say that without even knowing me?" Qi Jiao smiled gently. "I only scored a little over four hundred points on the zhongkao,² and I didn't even pass the undergraduate cutoff line for the gaokao.³ I accomplished nothing academically. If it weren't for my parents, I'd probably have starved on the streets."

"Was this shop opened with your parents' help?" Liang Shi asked.

Qi Jiao nodded. "And also my older brother and sister. They're all very accomplished. I'm like the control group.⁴ But red flowers always need green leaves to set them off."

"You're very accomplished too." Liang Shi said, "Not just anyone can open a shop."

Qi Jiao stuck her tongue out at her, the mud-stained hand patting her own forehead. "Oh no! I'm venting negativity to you again. I'm sorry, I hope I haven't ruined your good mood for the day."

Liang Shi shook her head. "You haven't. I'm very happy to meet you."

Her tone was very calm, even though she was saying the words "very happy."

Qi Jiao also detected something from this. She put her hands behind her back and smiled, "I hope so."

Liang Shi didn't want to affect her current life either, so she nodded with a smile. "I'll be going now."

"Okay." Qi Jiao said.

Liang Shi opened the black umbrella in her hand, her retreating figure looking desolate. She hadn't walked far when she heard Qi Jiao calling her from behind, "Miss Liang, wait."

Liang Shi turned around and saw Qi Jiao walking quickly toward her, pulling something out of her denim jacket pocket.

Qi Jiao said, "Hold out your hand."

Liang Shi numbly extended her hand. A few seconds later, two White Rabbit milk candies⁵ landed steadily in her palm.

Qi Jiao was still standing in the rain. Liang Shi moved her umbrella over to shelter her.

Qi Jiao smiled and shook her head. "No need, you keep it. I'm going back into the shop right away."

Liang Shi's throat felt a bit dry. "Why are you giving me these?"

"Don't be unhappy." Qi Jiao said, "Life will get better."

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1. Third year of middle school (初三, chūsān): In China's education system, middle school (junior high) consists of three years, typically ages 12-15. The third year is crucial as students prepare for the high school entrance examination. ↵
 2. Zhongkao (中考): The Senior High School Entrance Examination in China, taken at the end of middle school. It determines which high school a student can attend. A score of "a little over four hundred" is generally considered quite low. ↵
 3. Gaokao (高考): The National College Entrance Examination, China's highly competitive standardized test for university admission. Not passing the undergraduate cutoff line (本科线) means a student cannot enter a four-year university program. ↵
 4. Control group (对照组): Qi Jiao is using scientific terminology humorously, comparing herself to a "control group" in an experiment—suggesting she exists to make her accomplished siblings look even better by comparison. ↵
 5. White Rabbit milk candies (大白兔奶糖): A famous Chinese candy brand that has been around since 1959. These creamy, chewy milk-flavored candies wrapped in edible rice paper are nostalgic treats associated with childhood in China. The brand features a white rabbit logo on its packaging. ↵